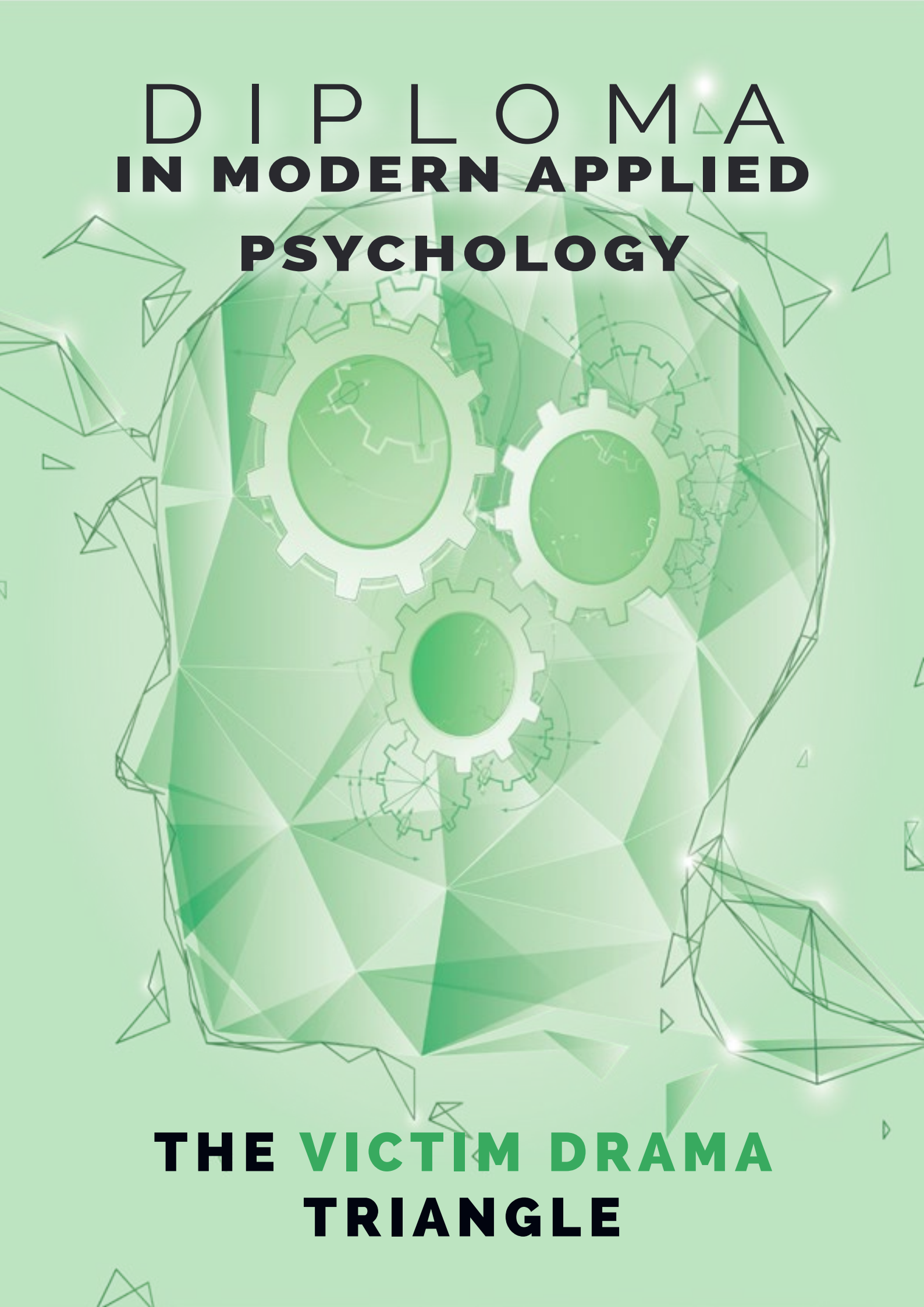


DIPLOMA IN MODERN APPLIED PSYCHOLOGY

The background is a light green field filled with various geometric shapes, primarily triangles and polygons, creating a low-poly or crystalline effect. In the center, there is a large, faint outline of a human skull. Overlaid on this skull are three interlocking gears of different sizes. The gears are rendered in a light green color with white outlines. The overall aesthetic is modern and technical, suggesting a connection between psychology and systems or mechanics.

THE VICTIM DRAMA TRIANGLE

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The Victim Drama Triangle (The Karpman Drama Triangle) is a social model developed by Stephen Karpman, who was studying under Eric Berne at the time, the pioneer of 'transactional analysis'.

The background of this development lies in WWII. As veterans made their way home to the United States, therapists noticed that some who had been progressing well in treatment whilst still away would suddenly regress once back at home. Researchers began to turn to look at the nature of family relationships and their effects on individuals. Some were found to have a positive benefit, whilst others were found to be very detrimental[1].

Then in 1966, Murray Bowen published his family systems theory. One of the critical components of this theory was that of triangulation. He held that in families if there is someone finds themselves in conflict with another family member, they will reach out to a third family member. This establishes a triangular relationship which is more comfortable than two-person conflict. We all use these triangles to create greater relational stability.

Karpman developed his model of the drama triangle and presented it in a paper in 1968 [2]. Karpman uses the model to map these dramatic relationship transactions. This straightforward model offers a considerable amount of potential insight into the sorts of roles we play in our lives.

Underpinning this concept are the connections between responsibility and power and their relationship to boundaries [3]. Karpman drew on transactional analysis theory to show how we develop a life script, which contains all our beliefs about who we are, what the world is like and how we relate to it, and how others relate to us. He identified the key roles that we play in these dramas of interaction and placed them into his triangle:

The Persecutor and the Rescuer are what he termed as 'one-up' positions whilst the Victim is a 'one down' position. Together they are the three faces of drama. Karpman was deliberately using language that related to acting, as he believes that we do actually 'play' these roles, so the victim need not be a real victim, but just acting 'as if'. Karpman contended that although we may all favour a role, we can switch dramatically between them.

The Roles:

The Victim

A victim is someone overwhelmed by their sense of vulnerability or powerlessness. They believe that the world is out to get them; they feel sorry for themselves and believe their lives are hopeless and oppressed. They seem unable to make decisions or tackle problems and find it hard to take pleasure in life. They will inevitably seek out a rescuer to take care of them. However, at some point they may well feel let down by their rescuer and move into a persecuting role, turning on their previous rescuer. They will still maintain their victim mindset, however. They may also seek out a persecutor to confirm their identity as a victim.

The Rescuer

The Rescuer is always on the lookout for the less fortunate. They believe that they can help others and make their lives better. They are the classic enabler and will feel guilty if they do not come to the rescue. However, Rescuers ultimately cultivate a culture of co-dependency and give Victim permission to stay dependent just so that the Rescuer can maintain their victim-rescuer dynamic. In this scenario, the Rescuer's subconscious motive is to avoid and suppress their own problems which they're refusing to address.



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The Persecutor

The Persecutor is the person who will tell you that everything is your fault, never their's. The Persecutor is controlling, blaming, critical, oppressive, angry, authoritative, rigid and superior.

We can all imagine scenarios where these roles are acted out. Imagine in the workplace: Beth is late and Jenny, her manager, starts telling her off. Beth takes the role of the victim and lists all the things that are going wrong for her, including a sick granny and a missed bus. Jenny assumes the role of persecutor and insists there are no excuses and she must be on time. Derrick, another manager, intervenes as the rescuer, giving credence to Beth's story of missed buses and her sick grandmother.

At this point, roles can shift. Perhaps Jenny could now become the victim by reacting to Derrick taking Beth's side. Derrick could persecute Jenny and attack her managerial abilities. Beth could then turn rescuer and decide to defend Jenny's position.

The application

The Drama Triangle is a useful tool in determining the sorts of roles we might be playing in our various relationships. It can help trigger self-awareness of what our real motives might be in a given triangle.

Each of these roles is assumed because an issue is being discounted or disowned. The causes need to be addressed:

- The Rescuer needs to take responsibility for themselves; they need to identify and tackle their own issues.
- The Victim also needs to take responsibility for themselves and to recognise that they have power and have the capacity to make progress without a rescuer.
- The Persecutor needs to connect with people and practice empathy.

As modern applied psychologists, we can use this model to help clients (and ourselves) come to a realisation of the nature of some of their interpersonal relationships and the roles they might have adopted. When we become aware of the life script that we're working from, we empower ourselves to make wiser choices. We no longer have to be trapped in the triangle and we don't have to be caught in roles. Instead, we can take responsibility for our actions and behaviours and make some significant changes in the world.

The Sweet Spot Between Superman Complex and Imposter Syndrome

Imposter syndrome, coined by clinical psychologists Pauline Clance and Suzanne Imes, isn't a psychological disorder. Instead, it's the term used to describe those enacting a pattern of disordered thinking in which they doubt their accomplishments and are become overwhelmed with the fear of being exposed as a fraud, despite having ample evidence to support their achievements and status in life.

On the other hand, the superman complex refers to a person's unhealthy sense of responsibility to the point that they risk their own safety and welfare for the benefit of others. People with a superman complex love helping people, but they do so with a naive mindset that they themselves are invincible. They regard all others are victims or mortals incapable of doing what they're capable of doing, so they step in and take control of situations or even, in some cases, people's lives.



THE VICTIM DRAMA TRIANGLE

The sweet spot between the two is when we accept that we don't have to be the top dog in life all of the time in order to feel appreciated and worthy, nor do we have to play the role of the underdog in order to maintain a level of humbleness.

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